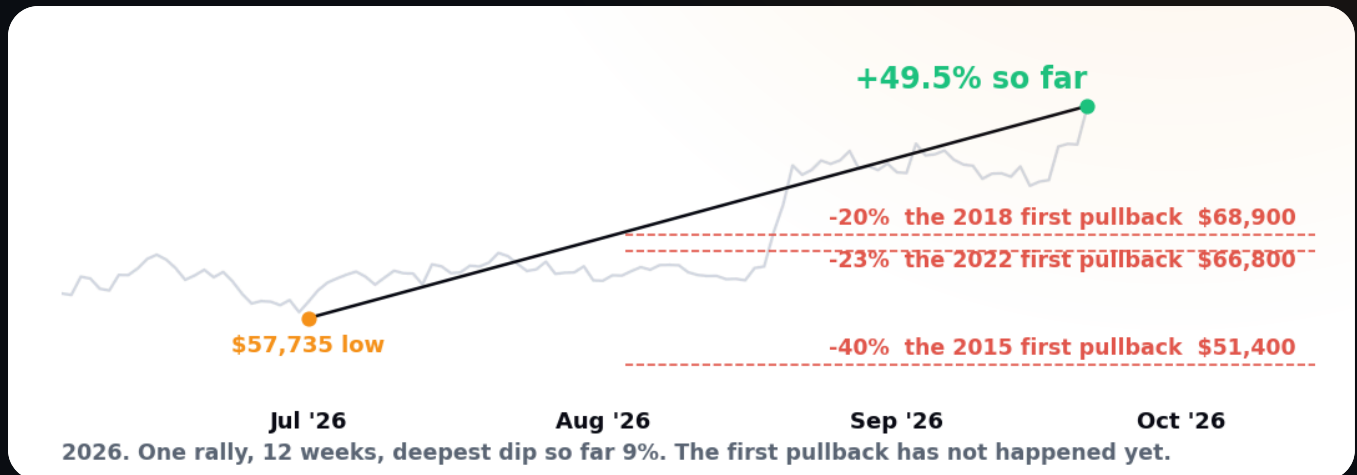


# THE FIRST PULLBACK STUDY

Bitcoin just broke \$82,833, the last lower high of this bear market. Every rally and every pullback after the 2015, 2018 and 2022 bottoms, measured leg by leg.

What the first rally off a real bottom looked like, what the first pullback did to it, and where a pullback of that size lands from here.



**12 of 16**

recovery pullbacks were  
20% or more

**-40 -20 -23**

the first pullback after each  
of the last three bottoms

**+49.5%**

this rally so far, with no  
pullback past 9%

Educational, not financial advice. Three recoveries is three recoveries. The legs are hand-measured on weekly wicks and checked against a second exchange, and the check is printed beside every one.



**Bitcoin Jae**  
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## THE LINE, AND WHY IT MATTERED

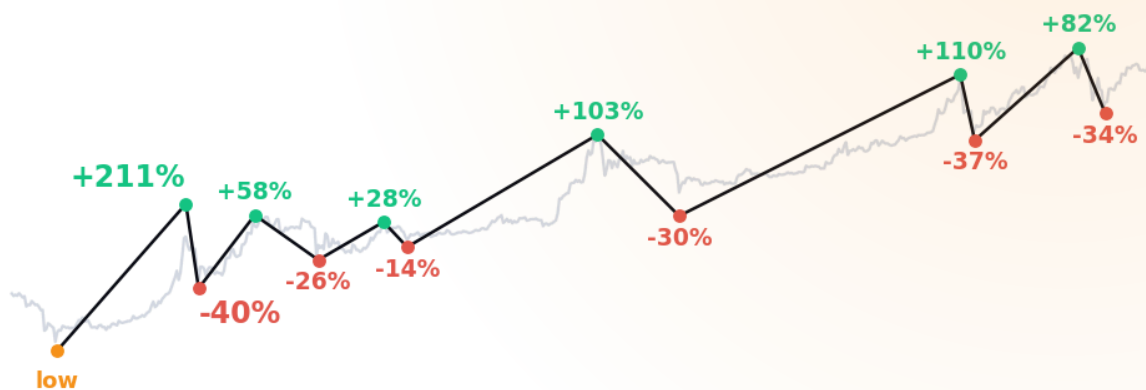


A bear market is a staircase down. Each rally tops out below the one before it, \$126,272 in October 2025, \$97,939 in January, \$82,833 in May. While that holds, every rally is a lower high and the structure is a bear. The staircase only ends when price gets back above the last step.

On 21 September 2026, in the 4am Eastern hour, Bitcoin went through \$82,833 on roughly ten times normal volume and ran to \$86,332, its highest since January. About \$648 million of short positions were liquidated on the way. At the time of writing there is no daily close above the level yet, and no weekly close. Both are part of the test this page has used all month.

So the useful question is not whether the bottom is in. It is what a recovery actually looks like if it is. The next three pages measure every leg of the last three.

## AFTER THE 2015 BOTTOM



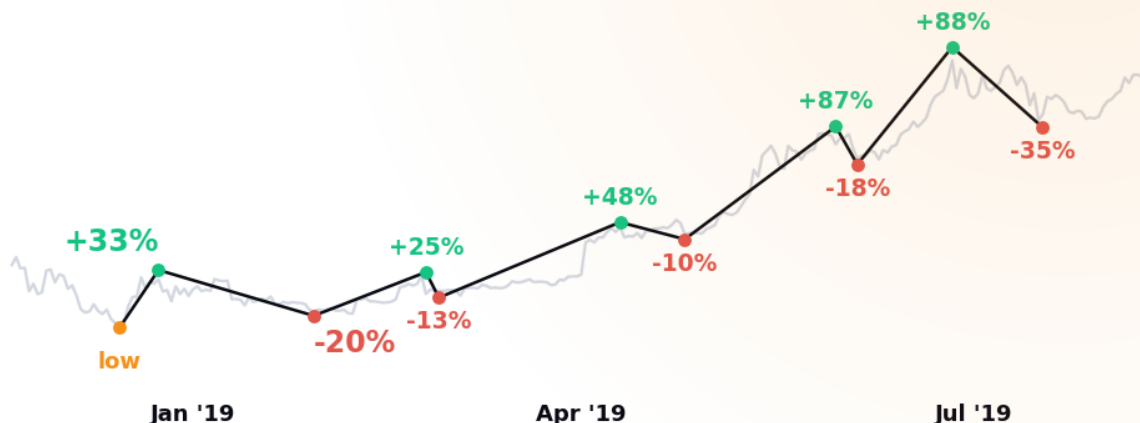
Aug '15 Nov '15 Feb '16 May '16 Aug '16 Nov '16 Feb '17 May '17  
After the 2015 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

| #  | LEG      | FROM        | TO          | START   | END     | MEASURED | BITSTAMP | WEEKS |
|----|----------|-------------|-------------|---------|---------|----------|----------|-------|
| 1  | rally    | 25 Aug 2015 | 04 Nov 2015 | \$198   | \$502   | +211%    | +153%    | 10    |
| 2  | pullback | 04 Nov 2015 | 11 Nov 2015 | \$502   | \$294   | -40%     | -41%     | 1     |
| 3  | rally    | 11 Nov 2015 | 12 Dec 2015 | \$294   | \$468   | +58%     | +59%     | 4     |
| 4  | pullback | 12 Dec 2015 | 16 Jan 2016 | \$468   | \$352   | -26%     | -25%     | 5     |
| 5  | rally    | 16 Jan 2016 | 21 Feb 2016 | \$352   | \$448   | +28%     | +27%     | 5     |
| 6  | pullback | 21 Feb 2016 | 05 Mar 2016 | \$448   | \$382   | -14%     | -15%     | 2     |
| 7  | rally    | 05 Mar 2016 | 18 Jun 2016 | \$382   | \$779   | +103%    | +104%    | 15    |
| 8  | pullback | 18 Jun 2016 | 02 Aug 2016 | \$779   | \$465   | -30%     | -40%     | 6     |
| 9  | rally    | 02 Aug 2016 | 04 Jan 2017 | \$465   | \$1,140 | +110%    | +145%    | 22    |
| 10 | pullback | 04 Jan 2017 | 12 Jan 2017 | \$1,140 | \$751   | -37%     | -34%     | 1     |
| 11 | rally    | 12 Jan 2017 | 10 Mar 2017 | \$751   | \$1,350 | +82%     | +80%     | 8     |
| 12 | pullback | 10 Mar 2017 | 25 Mar 2017 | \$1,350 | \$891   | -34%     | -34%     | 2     |

*Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check. 2015 was drawn on Bitfinex, whose August 2015 and August 2016 wicks differ from Bitstamp's.*

The first rally tripled price in ten weeks. Then it gave back 40% in a single week. Six pullbacks on the way up, five of them 20% or more, and the recovery still carried price to almost 7 times its low on Bitstamp.

## AFTER THE 2018 BOTTOM



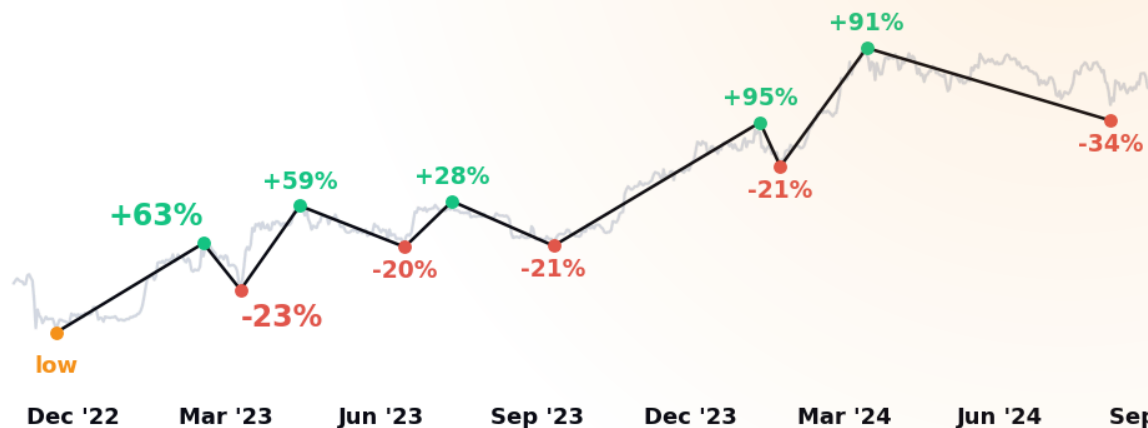
After the 2018 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

| #  | LEG      | FROM        | TO          | START    | END      | MEASURED | BITSTAMP | WEEKS |
|----|----------|-------------|-------------|----------|----------|----------|----------|-------|
| 1  | rally    | 15 Dec 2018 | 24 Dec 2018 | \$3,122  | \$4,237  | +33%     | +36%     | 1     |
| 2  | pullback | 24 Dec 2018 | 29 Jan 2019 | \$4,237  | \$3,322  | -20%     | -22%     | 5     |
| 3  | rally    | 29 Jan 2019 | 24 Feb 2019 | \$3,322  | \$4,190  | +25%     | +26%     | 4     |
| 4  | pullback | 24 Feb 2019 | 27 Feb 2019 | \$4,190  | \$3,658  | -13%     | -13%     | 1     |
| 5  | rally    | 27 Feb 2019 | 10 Apr 2019 | \$3,658  | \$5,466  | +48%     | +49%     | 6     |
| 6  | pullback | 10 Apr 2019 | 25 Apr 2019 | \$5,466  | \$4,991  | -10%     | -9%      | 2     |
| 7  | rally    | 25 Apr 2019 | 30 May 2019 | \$4,991  | \$9,097  | +87%     | +82%     | 5     |
| 8  | pullback | 30 May 2019 | 04 Jun 2019 | \$9,097  | \$7,433  | -18%     | -18%     | 1     |
| 9  | rally    | 04 Jun 2019 | 26 Jun 2019 | \$7,433  | \$13,880 | +88%     | +87%     | 3     |
| 10 | pullback | 26 Jun 2019 | 17 Jul 2019 | \$13,880 | \$9,050  | -35%     | -35%     | 3     |

*Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check.*

The first rally was the smallest of the three, +33% in nine days. The first pullback took five weeks, gave back 20% and stopped 6% above the low. It looked exactly like a failed rally. Price then quadrupled in five months. This recovery never reached a new all-time high before the 2020 crash, so its chart ends at the June 2019 peak and the 35% drop that followed.

## RECOVERY THREE AFTER THE 2022 BOTTOM



After the 2022 bottom. Every rally and pullback of the recovery, measured on weekly wicks. Log scale.

| #  | LEG      | FROM        | TO          | START    | END      | MEASURED | BITSTAMP | WEEKS |
|----|----------|-------------|-------------|----------|----------|----------|----------|-------|
| 1  | rally    | 21 Nov 2022 | 16 Feb 2023 | \$15,479 | \$25,270 | +63%     | +63%     | 12    |
| 2  | pullback | 16 Feb 2023 | 10 Mar 2023 | \$25,270 | \$19,569 | -23%     | -23%     | 3     |
| 3  | rally    | 10 Mar 2023 | 14 Apr 2023 | \$19,569 | \$31,035 | +59%     | +59%     | 5     |
| 4  | pullback | 14 Apr 2023 | 15 Jun 2023 | \$31,035 | \$24,756 | -20%     | -20%     | 9     |
| 5  | rally    | 15 Jun 2023 | 13 Jul 2023 | \$24,756 | \$31,818 | +28%     | +29%     | 4     |
| 6  | pullback | 13 Jul 2023 | 11 Sep 2023 | \$31,818 | \$24,920 | -21%     | -22%     | 9     |
| 7  | rally    | 11 Sep 2023 | 11 Jan 2024 | \$24,920 | \$49,048 | +95%     | +97%     | 17    |
| 8  | pullback | 11 Jan 2024 | 23 Jan 2024 | \$49,048 | \$38,505 | -21%     | -21%     | 2     |
| 9  | rally    | 23 Jan 2024 | 14 Mar 2024 | \$38,505 | \$73,794 | +91%     | +92%     | 7     |
| 10 | pullback | 14 Mar 2024 | 05 Aug 2024 | \$73,794 | \$49,577 | -34%     | -33%     | 21    |

*Measured = weekly wicks on the chart the leg was drawn on. Bitstamp = the same leg on Bitstamp daily wicks, as a check.*

The cleanest of the three. +63%, then -23%, and then every single pullback on the way up was 20% or more, five of five. Price still went up almost five times. A 20% drop was not a sign the recovery had failed. It was the rhythm of it.

## ALL 32 LEGS

# THE FIRST PULLBACK IS THE ONE THAT MATTERS

| BOTTOM | FIRST RALLY   | TOOK | FIRST PULLBACK | TOOK | PULLBACK LOW VS THE BOTTOM | PULLBACKS OF 20%+ |
|--------|---------------|------|----------------|------|----------------------------|-------------------|
| 2015   | +211%         | 10w  | -40%           | 1w   | +48%                       | 5 of 6            |
| 2018   | +33%          | 1w   | -20%           | 5w   | +6%                        | 2 of 5            |
| 2022   | +63%          | 12w  | -23%           | 3w   | +26%                       | 5 of 5            |
| 2026   | +49.5% so far | 12w  | not yet        |      |                            |                   |

*All three first pullbacks held above the bottom. That hold is what made it the bottom.*

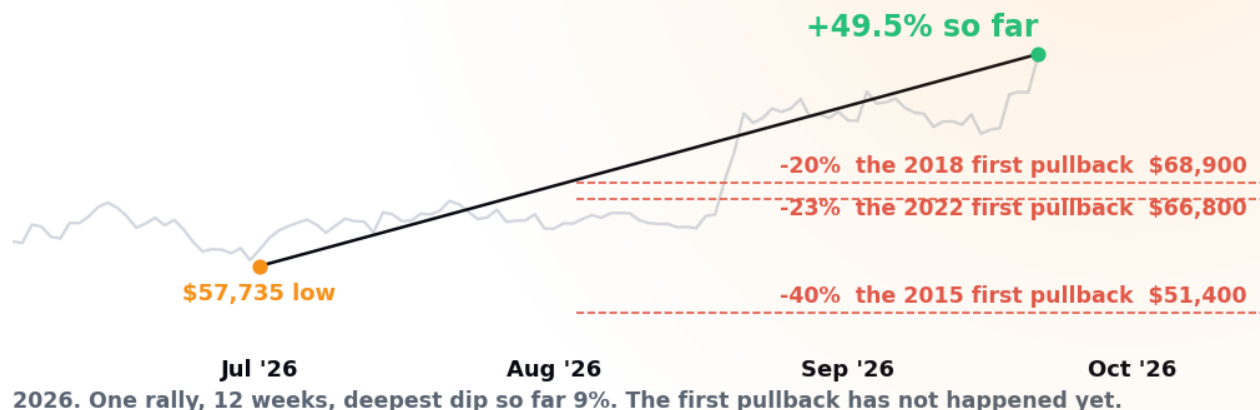
Across the three recoveries there were 16 rallies and 16 pullbacks. The typical rally was +73% and the smallest +25%. The typical pullback was -22%, the shallowest -10%, the deepest -40%. 12 of 16 pullbacks were 20% or more and 5 were 30% or more. Each of the three charts ends with a drop of about a third, -34%, -35% and -34%.

After every one of the three bottoms the very first rally got sold, by 40%, 20% and 23%. None of those first rallies told you the bottom was in. A first rally off a low looks the same in a recovery and in a bear market rally. What separated them was the pullback. In all three recoveries it stopped above the low, and in the bear market rallies of this cycle it did not.

### THE FINDING

The first rally never told you. The first pullback did.

# 2026, ONE RALLY AND NO PULLBACK YET



| IF THE FIRST PULLBACK MATCHES | SIZE | FROM THE \$86,332 HIGH | AGAINST THE \$57,735 LOW |
|-------------------------------|------|------------------------|--------------------------|
| 2018                          | -20% | \$68,900               | holds above              |
| 2022                          | -23% | \$66,800               | holds above              |
| 2015                          | -40% | \$51,400               | breaks below             |

*Levels move up if the rally makes a higher high first. They are analogs, not targets.*

From the 1 July low at \$57,735 Bitcoin is up 49.5% in twelve weeks, and the deepest dip inside the rally so far is 9%. By the record of the last three recoveries the first real pullback has not happened yet. A 2018 or 2022 sized one from the current high lands at roughly \$68,900 to \$66,800, which sits just above the pullback zone this page published on 3 September. A 2015 sized one lands under the low, which would make this rally one more lower high.

## THE READ

**Bull case or bear case, a 20% pullback is ahead. This is a study, not a call.**

## ALL 19 GRADED BREAKS OF THE LAST LOWER HIGH

| BREAK       | LEVEL    | DAYS FROM LOW | UP FROM LOW | +30D | +90D  | +180D | WORST DIP 90D |      |
|-------------|----------|---------------|-------------|------|-------|-------|---------------|------|
| 20 Dec 2011 | \$4      | 25            | +82%        | +37% | +6%   | +36%  | -16%          |      |
| 18 Apr 2012 | \$5      | 145           | +106%       | -2%  | +66%  | +126% | -7%           |      |
| 19 Aug 2013 | \$100    | 129           | +129%       | +23% | +364% | +538% | -17%          |      |
| 25 May 2014 | \$548    | 44            | +69%        | -0%  | -13%  | -39%  | -23%          | TRAP |
| 12 Nov 2014 | \$418    | 38            | +55%        | -17% | -48%  | -43%  | -64%          | TRAP |
| 02 Mar 2015 | \$268    | 47            | +80%        | -10% | -17%  | -16%  | -24%          |      |
| 16 Jun 2015 | \$247    | 153           | +64%        | +11% | -8%   | +73%  | -21%          |      |
| 06 Oct 2015 | \$246    | 265           | +62%        | +56% | +76%  | +70%  | -2%           |      |
| 15 Apr 2016 | \$428    | 457           | +182%       | +7%  | +53%  | +48%  | -1%           |      |
| 11 Oct 2016 | \$629    | 636           | +319%       | +12% | +40%  | +89%  | -2%           |      |
| 23 Feb 2019 | \$4,112  | 70            | +32%        | -5%  | +94%  | +146% | -11%          |      |
| 26 Oct 2019 | \$8,820  | 315           | +196%       | -23% | -9%   | -19%  | -31%          |      |
| 23 Apr 2020 | \$7,469  | 495           | +140%       | +23% | +27%  | +59%  | -1%           |      |
| 10 Oct 2020 | \$11,183 | 665           | +262%       | +36% | +260% | +414% | -1%           |      |
| 26 Oct 2022 | \$20,469 | 130           | +18%        | -21% | +9%   | +32%  | -25%          | TRAP |
| 12 Jan 2023 | \$18,373 | 52            | +22%        | +16% | +59%  | +62%  | -1%           |      |
| 21 Jun 2023 | \$28,452 | 212           | +94%        | -0%  | -9%   | +42%  | -17%          |      |
| 23 Oct 2023 | \$30,210 | 336           | +114%       | +13% | +26%  | +96%  | -1%           |      |
| 17 Apr 2026 | \$76,013 | 70            | +29%        | +0%  | -17%  |       | -25%          | TRAP |
| 19 Aug 2026 | \$66,921 | 49            | +20%        | +17% |       |       | -1%           |      |

Bitstamp daily. Bear state = 35%+ under the all-time high. Last lower high on 14-day wick pivots. Break = first daily close above it. TRAP = a new bear-market low followed. The August 2026 row is too recent to grade and is not in the 19.

Every time Bitcoin closed above its last lower high inside a bear market, 19 graded cases. After 15 of them no new low ever followed. Four were traps. Split by how early the break came and the picture changes. Breaks within 90 days of the low, 7 cases, 3 traps, and 90 days later a median -13%. Later breaks, 12 cases, 1 trap, +34%. The September 2026 break comes on day 82, and this bear already produced one trap, the 17 April close above \$76,013.

## WHAT THIS STUDY DOES NOT SAY

**Three recoveries.** Every statistic on the legs comes from three charts. They describe what recoveries have looked like, not what this one must do.

**The legs are hand-measured.** Where a leg starts and ends is a judgement. That is why every leg is printed with its dates, its prices and a second-exchange check, so you can disagree with any of them.

**The recoveries are known in hindsight.** The three bottoms are only bottoms because the first pullback held. In real time a first rally off a low and a bear market rally are the same object, which is the entire point of the first-pullback table.

**The break is not confirmed.** At the time of writing there is no daily or weekly close above \$82,833, and price sits 32% under its all-time high, just outside the 35% rule used for the trap table. Breaks this early were traps three times in seven.

*Data pinned 21 September 2026, 11:44am ET. Legs measured on weekly wicks (2015 Bitfinex, 2018 and 2022 Binance), checked on Bitstamp BTC/USD daily wicks. Scripts: Legs/legs\_charts.py, LowerHigh/lh\_study.py. This is education, not financial advice.*

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